

INDEPENDENT RESEARCH STUDY

How do students perceive the effects of social media consumption on their productivity & wellbeing?

A mixed-methods study contrasting the findings of a 380-student survey against the leading literature

Scott L. Roberts

FdSc ICT Systems, University of South Wales

April 2026
Approx. 5,500 words

sroberts.dev

Introduction.....	2
Literature Review	4
Section 1: The Scale of Social Media Use	4
Section 2: Social Media and Academic Performance	4
Section 3: Social Media, Wellbeing and Mental Health.....	5
Section 4: Addiction, Self-Esteem and Life Satisfaction	6
Section 5: The Attention Economy, Digital Minimalism and Self-Regulation.....	6
Methodology.....	7
Findings & Discussion.....	8
Theme 1 - Usage Patterns and Motivation	8
Theme 2 - Perceived Academic Impact.....	10
Theme 3 - Wellbeing Effects	11
Theme 4 - Self-Regulation and the Desire for Change	12
Evaluation	13
Conclusions	14
References.....	15

Introduction

Social media has become one of the most influential parts of modern digital life, particularly amongst younger people and students. Platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat, YouTube and X now play a major role in everyday life, affecting how people communicate, learn, socialise and spend their free time. For many students, social media is no longer simply a form of entertainment, but an essential part of their daily routine, used to maintain friendships, access news, share ideas, collaborate on academic work and discover educational content. However, alongside these benefits, concerns have also grown about how excessive social media use may affect productivity, concentration and wellbeing.

Students today are studying in an environment where constant digital connectivity is normalised. Notifications, messages, endless scrolling feeds and algorithm-driven content constantly compete for users' attention throughout the day, a phenomenon increasingly described by researchers and commentators as the "attention economy," in which technology platforms are deliberately designed to maximise engagement at the expense of focus (Williams, 2018). As a result, many students experience regular interruptions whilst studying, revising or completing assignments, contributing to concerns around procrastination, reduced concentration and lower academic performance. In addition, issues such as stress, anxiety, poor sleep quality, social comparison and dependency on digital stimulation have all been linked to patterns of heavy social media use.

Despite these concerns, the relationship between social media and student life is complex and should not be reduced to a simple narrative of harm. Social media can provide genuine benefits when used responsibly - many students use online platforms to communicate with classmates, join study groups, watch tutorials, follow academic creators and access motivational or educational material. During periods of remote learning and social isolation, digital platforms proved especially valuable for maintaining social connection and support networks. Therefore, the effects of social media may depend significantly on how, why and how often it is used, rather than on use itself.

This growing tension between the costs and benefits of digital life has contributed to increasing interest in the concept of digital minimalism, a philosophy explored by Cal Newport in his 2019 book of the same name, which advocates for intentional and selective technology use as a means of reclaiming focus, balance and quality of life. Online communities, particularly on platforms such as Reddit, have emerged around this idea, populated largely by students and young people sharing their experiences and strategies for managing screen time. The existence of these communities is telling in and of itself; it suggests that awareness of the problem is widespread and that many students are already seeking solutions independently.

This independent study aims to investigate the question: *How do students perceive the effects of social media consumption on their productivity and wellbeing?* The focus is deliberately on student perceptions rather than attempting to establish a direct causal relationship. Understanding perception is valuable because it reveals how students themselves interpret their habits, challenges and coping strategies, and whether they are already engaging in self-regulatory behaviours such as screen time limits, app blockers or more mindful patterns of use.

I have chosen this topic due to both its wider social relevance and my own personal interest. As a student, I have observed the growing influence of social media in academic environments and have personally experienced some of the challenges associated with constant digital access. This led to a deeper interest in how students navigate these pressures and whether healthier, more intentional relationships with technology can be cultivated.

To explore this topic, both primary and secondary research methods were employed. Primary research was conducted through an online student survey designed to gather perspectives on distraction, motivation, academic performance, stress, mood, sleep quality and self-regulation. Secondary research drew upon academic journals, books, online discussions and other relevant sources examining attention, technology habits and student wellbeing. Combining these approaches allows for a broader understanding of both established research and current student experience.

Before collecting the results, I expected the findings to reflect a balanced perspective, many students may acknowledge that social media can be distracting and at times harmful to their productivity or wellbeing, whilst also recognising its value for communication, relaxation and learning. Ultimately, this report will examine how students navigate one of the defining challenges of modern education: balancing the opportunities of digital connection with the

need for focus, discipline and wellbeing, and whether the development of intentional, self-regulated digital habits may be one of the most important skills students can cultivate.

Literature Review

Section 1: The Scale of Social Media Use

Social media has become one of the defining features of modern life, with its growth over the past two decades representing one of the most significant shifts in human communication and behaviour. Platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, Snapchat and X have accumulated billions of users globally, fundamentally changing how people interact, consume information and spend their leisure time. Whilst this growth has brought undeniable benefits to socialisation and communication, it has also brought about a growing concern amongst researchers, educators and health professionals regarding its effects on the wellbeing and academic performance of younger users.

Students and young people represent some of the heaviest users of social media, with usage patterns often extending into late-night hours and overlapping with study time (Kirschner and Karpinski, 2010). Twenge and Campbell (2018), in one of the largest studies conducted on this topic, examined a nationally representative sample of over 40,000 children and adolescents in the United States and found that screen time increased substantially with age, a finding with significant implications for the student population that forms the focus of this study.

Crucially, the relationship between social media platforms and its users is not passive. Platforms are designed with the explicit goal of maximising engagement, employing algorithms, notifications, and variable-reward mechanics to retain user attention for as long as possible (Newport, 2019). Due to this, scholars such as James Williams (2018) describe the modern digital landscape as an “attention economy” in which human focus has become the primary commodity and technology companies compete aggressively to capture and hold it. Johann Hari (2022) extends this argument in *Stolen Focus*, suggesting that the effect of these design choices has caused a measurable deterioration in society's capacity for sustained concentration, a concern that is particularly important with regards to students, whose academic success depends heavily on the ability to focus deeply.

Section 2: Social Media and Academic Performance

One of the most widely researched consequences of social media use amongst students is its potential impact on academic performance. Kirschner and Karpinski (2010) conducted one of the first systematic studies in this area, surveying 219 undergraduate and graduate students at a large American university. Their findings were striking: Facebook users reported significantly lower grade point averages and spent considerably fewer hours per week studying than non-users, with the authors attributing this to the tendency to engage with social platforms whilst studying, arguing that such divided attention is cognitively detrimental and impairs the processing and retention of academic material.

What makes these findings particularly relevant to this study, however, is not simply the quantitative results but the qualitative gap they revealed. Despite the data suggesting a clear negative relationship between Facebook use and academic outcomes, the majority of student participants, over 73%, reported believing that Facebook had no impact on their academic performance. This disconnect between perceived and actual impact is significant: it suggests that students systematically underestimate the extent to which social media interferes with their studies; this finding raises important questions about self-awareness and the accuracy of self-reported perceptions, which form the basis of the present survey-based investigation.

More recent research has reinforced and added to these early findings. Hou et al. (2019) examined the relationship between social media addiction and academic performance amongst college students in China, finding a significant negative link between addictive social media use and self-reported academic ranking relative to their peers. Crucially, their study also tested a cognitive-behavioural intervention and found that participants who took part not only reported lower levels of addictive use but also spent more time studying and showed greater learning engagement compared to a control group. This suggests that the relationship between social media use and academic outcomes is not fixed, that intentional behavioural change can meaningfully improve both.

It is important to note, however, that the relationship is not entirely one-sided. Some studies have found that social media can support academic activity when used with purpose, joining study groups, accessing educational content or following academic creators. The key distinction may therefore lie not in social media use itself but in the intentionality and context of that use, a nuance that the present study seeks to explore.

Section 3: Social Media, Wellbeing and Mental Health

Alongside its effects on academic performance, social media use has been increasingly linked to a range of wellbeing and mental health outcomes amongst young people, driven by rising rates of anxiety, depression and poor sleep quality amongst adolescents and young adults, trends which many researchers have linked, at least in part, to the growth of social media and screen-based technologies.

Twenge and Campbell (2018) produced some of the most compelling large-scale evidence in this area. Their study found that beyond one hour of screen use a day, psychological wellbeing declined progressively with each additional hour. Users spending seven or more hours per day were more than twice as likely to have been diagnosed with depression or anxiety compared to low users, with moderate users of four hours also significantly more likely to report lower wellbeing across measures including emotional stability, self-control and the ability to complete tasks. Twenge and Campbell suggest that associations were strongest amongst adolescents because this age group is more likely to hold social media accounts, and that when digital interaction replaces face-to-face socialisation, the wellbeing benefits of real-world connection may be lost.

The relationship between social media and self-esteem represents a particularly important thread within this topic. Hawi and Samaha (2016) investigated addictive social media use, self-esteem and life satisfaction amongst university students in Lebanon, finding that higher addiction levels were associated with lower self-esteem. Critically, self-esteem acted as a

mediating factor, social media addiction did not directly reduce life satisfaction, but did so indirectly by first lowering self-esteem. This finding was supported by Hou et al. (2019), whose study of Chinese college students identified the same mediating role, suggesting that the harm social media causes to wellbeing may operate gradually through its erosion of how students perceive and value themselves.

A plausible explanation lies in social comparison culture. Platforms such as Instagram encourage users to present curated, idealised versions of their lives, which can foster a distorted sense that others are happier or more successful (Hawi and Samaha, 2016), a dynamic that may be especially damaging for students already navigating the pressures of academic life. Overall, the evidence suggests that wellbeing outcomes may depend on the way social media is used and the reasons for using it, rather than use itself.

Section 4: Addiction, Self-Esteem and Life Satisfaction

Whilst the previous section explored the broader relationship between social media and wellbeing, a more specific body of research has focused on social media addiction and its consequences for self-esteem and life satisfaction amongst university students. Griffiths (2013) proposed a widely adopted six-component framework, salience, tolerance, mood modification, withdrawal, relapse and conflict, describing patterns of compulsive use that interfere with relationships and academic responsibilities. This framework underpins several validated measurement instruments, most notably the Bergen Social Media Addiction Scale (BSMAS), developed by Andreassen et al. (2016) and widely used across the international research drawn upon in this review.

Using the BSMAS, Simsek et al. (2019) studied 700 high school and university students in Turkey, finding that duration of daily use was the strongest predictor of addiction, students using social media for more than five hours per day showed significantly higher addiction scores than those using it for less than an hour, directly reinforcing Twenge and Campbell's (2018) wellbeing threshold findings. Gender was also a significant variable, with female students reporting higher addiction scores, particularly when it came to mood modification and withdrawal, a finding echoed by Hawi and Samaha (2016). Both studies caution against overgeneralisation, noting that cultural and contextual factors may influence results across different populations.

The research in this area appears to paint a consistent picture. Addictive patterns of social media use are associated with lower self-esteem, reduced life satisfaction and poorer mental health outcomes amongst university students, a slow erosion of self-perception driven by compulsive checking, social comparison and the emotional highs and lows of online interaction that may go unnoticed until deeply embedded in daily habit.

Section 5: The Attention Economy, Digital Minimalism and Self-Regulation

The evidence reviewed so far raises an important question: if social media use is so widely associated with negative outcomes, why do students continue to use it in ways that harm them? Part of the answer lies in understanding how these platforms are designed. Social

media companies operate within what scholars have called the "attention economy", a system in which user attention is the primary commodity and platforms are engineered to capture and hold it for as long as possible (Williams, 2018). Newport (2019) argues that this design philosophy has fundamentally altered the relationship between individuals and their devices, creating habitual checking behaviours that operate outside of conscious awareness. Johann Hari (2022), in *Stolen Focus*, suggests the cumulative effect has been a decline in society's ability for concentration, a particularly acute challenge for students whose academic success depends on deep focus.

In response, a growing movement has emerged around the concept of digital minimalism, defined by Newport (2019) as a philosophy of intentional, selective technology use focused on activities that genuinely support personal values. Online communities, particularly on platforms such as Reddit, have grown significantly around this idea, with many students sharing strategies for reducing screen time and developing healthier relationships with technology. Significantly, the intervention tested by Hou et al. (2019), involving cognitive reconstruction, reminder techniques and daily reflection, mirrors many of these strategies, a seemingly meaningful crossover between grassroots self-help approaches and clinical research findings.

If students are already independently developing strategies to manage their social media use, understanding how effective they perceive those strategies to be offers a valuable insight into the self-regulatory capacity of the student population and the potential for more structured support.

Methodology

This study used a mixed-methods approach, combining primary research in the form of an online student survey with secondary research from a variety of academic journals, books and other relevant sources. This combination allowed for both an evidence-based theoretical foundation and a set of original findings through the direct experiences and perceptions of students themselves.

The primary research method was a twenty question online survey created using Microsoft Forms and distributed to students over a period of 86 days, ultimately gathering 380 responses. The survey was designed to gather student perspectives across four key areas: social media usage patterns, perceived academic impact, wellbeing effects, and self-regulatory behaviours. Questions employed a mixture of formats including Likert scales, multiple choice and ranking questions, allowing for both quantitative measurement and a degree of nuanced response. The survey was distributed digitally via student networks and peer sharing, reaching predominantly UK university students, though the self-selecting nature of online participation should be considered when interpreting the findings.

It is important to acknowledge several limitations of this approach. As a self-report survey, the data reflects student perceptions rather than objectively measured behaviour, meaning responses may be subject to social desirability bias, the tendency for participants to answer in

ways they consider more acceptable rather than entirely honestly. Additionally, whilst 380 responses represents a strong sample size for an independent study at this level, the sampling method was non-random and convenience-based, meaning that the results cannot be considered fully representative of the wider student population. The age range and demographic background of respondents was also not formally recorded, which limits the extent to which findings can be broken down by subgroup.

Secondary research was conducted through a review of existing academic literature, focusing on peer-reviewed journal articles examining social media addiction, academic performance, student wellbeing and self-regulation. Key sources included studies published in journals such as *Computers in Human Behaviour*, *Social Science Computer Review*, *Preventive Medicine Reports*, *Contemporary Educational Technology* and *Cyberpsychology: Journal of Psychosocial Research on Cyberspace*. As well as academic journals, this study drew upon books including Newport's *Digital Minimalism* (2019) and Hari's *Stolen Focus* (2022), which provided broader cultural and philosophical context for the findings. Online communities, particularly discussion threads on Reddit relating to digital minimalism and screen time management, were also used as observational sources reflecting student attitudes.

Ethical considerations were observed throughout the research process. Participation in the survey was entirely voluntary and anonymous, no personally identifying information was collected. The subject matter of the study was made clear to participants through the survey title, '*Student Perspectives on Social Media Consumption, Productivity, and Wellbeing*', and participants were under no obligation to take part. All secondary sources have been cited in accordance with Harvard referencing conventions.

Findings & Discussion

The survey gathered 380 responses from UK University students over a period of 86 days, producing a substantial dataset across all twenty questions. The findings are discussed below in relation to four key themes that emerged from the data: usage patterns and motivation, perceived academic impact, wellbeing effects, and self-regulation and the desire for change. Where relevant, findings are connected to the existing literature reviewed earlier in this report.

Theme 1 - Usage Patterns and Motivation

The data collected revealed that social media use amongst the surveyed students is both extensive and mainly habitual. The majority of respondents reported spending between two to four hours per day on social media, with 82 students selecting the 3-4 hour bracket, the single most common response (*see Figure 1*). More strikingly, approximately 40% of respondents reported using social media for four or more hours daily, a figure that is particularly significant when considering Twenge and Campbell's (2018) finding that psychological wellbeing begins to decline meaningfully beyond four hours of daily screen use.

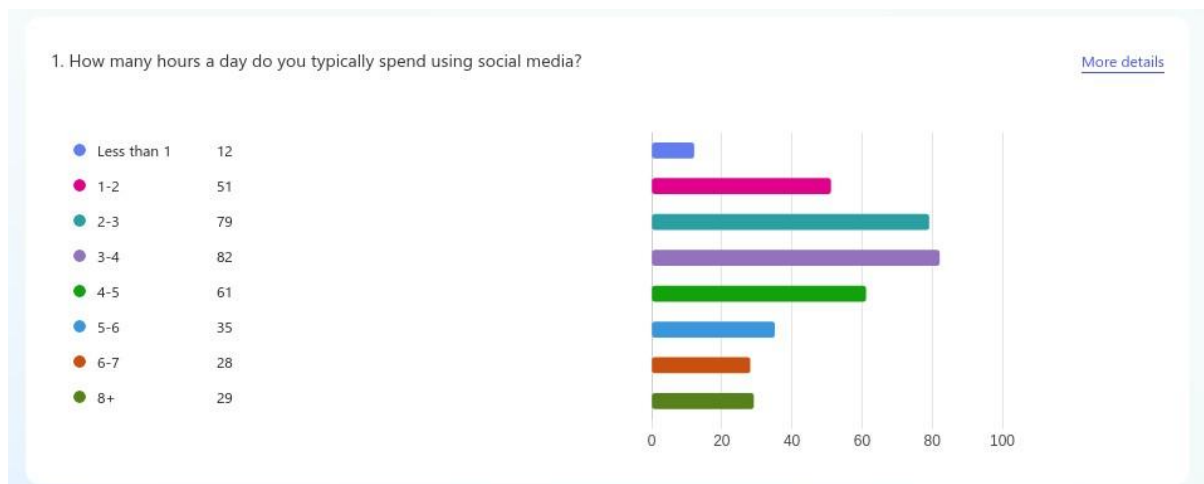


Figure 1: Student responses to daily social media usage hours (n=380)

When asked their primary reason for social media use, 53% of respondents cited entertainment and 38% cited habit or boredom (see Figure 2), together accounting for 91% of responses. Only 2% identified academic interests as their primary motivation. The vast majority of students are spending several hours every day on platforms they use primarily out of habit rather than intention, whilst those same platforms are identified as significant sources of academic disruption. This aligns with Newport's (2019) argument that often social media use is not a conscious choice but a conditioned response, the result of platform design engineered to generate automatic, reflexive checking behaviours.

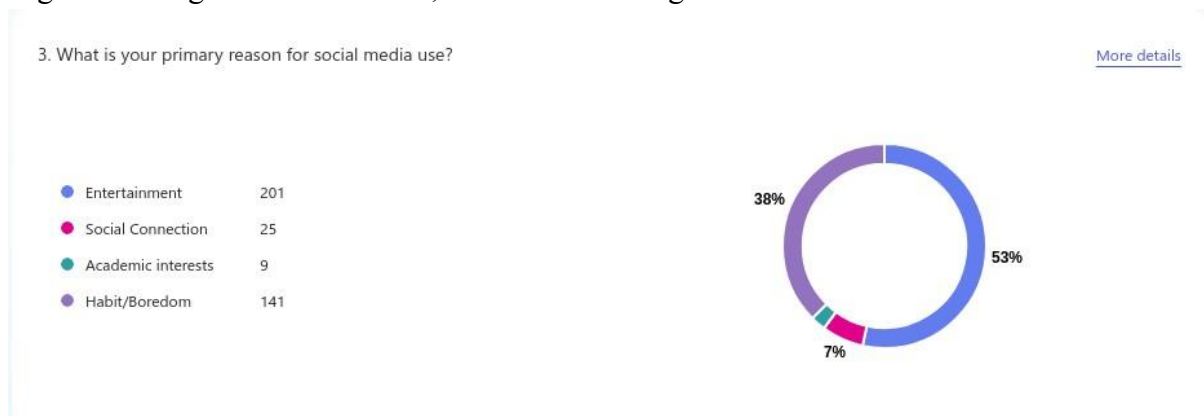


Figure 2: Student responses to primary motivation for social media use (n=380)

YouTube emerged as the most used platform by a considerable margin, selected by 187 respondents, followed by Instagram at 100 and TikTok at 62 (see Figure 3). Facebook was selected by just 6 respondents- a finding worth noting given that much of the academic literature reviewed, including Kirschner and Karpinski (2010) and Hawi and Samaha (2016), focused primarily on Facebook. This generational shift in platform preference suggests that whilst patterns of use and their consequences appear consistent across platforms, future research may benefit from focusing more specifically on newer platforms such as TikTok and Instagram, whose algorithmic design and content formats differ significantly from earlier social networking sites.

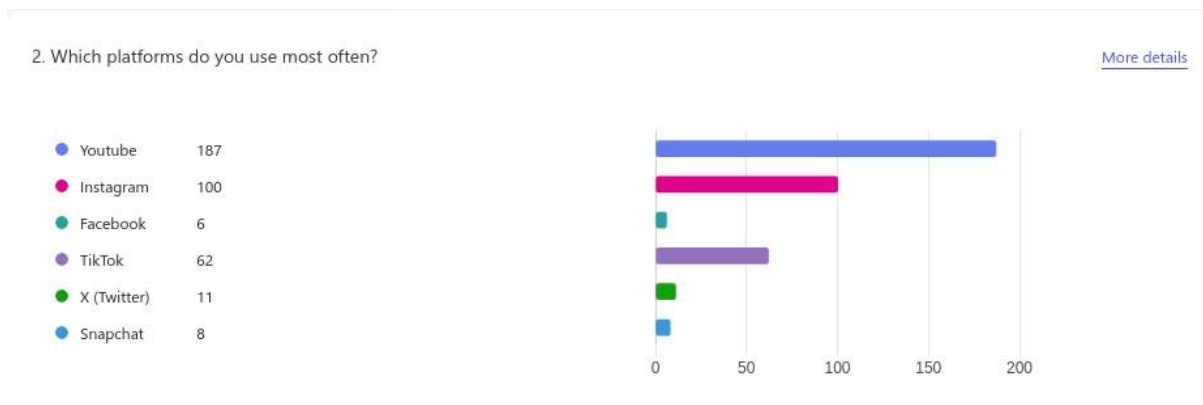


Figure 3: Most used social media platforms amongst respondents (n=380)

Theme 2 - Perceived Academic Impact

The survey findings paint a clear picture of widespread perceived academic disruption. Question 4 asked students to rate on a scale of 1-5 the extent to which social media distracts them from completing academic tasks, producing an average rating of 3.89 (see Figure 4), indicating that the majority of students experience meaningful distraction. Question 5, which asked how often students check social media whilst studying or doing assignments, gave a similarly high average of 3.79, with approximately 66% of respondents selecting level 4 or 5. When asked directly whether social media negatively impacts their academic performance, 61.4% agreed or strongly agreed, with only 18% disagreeing (see Figure 5).

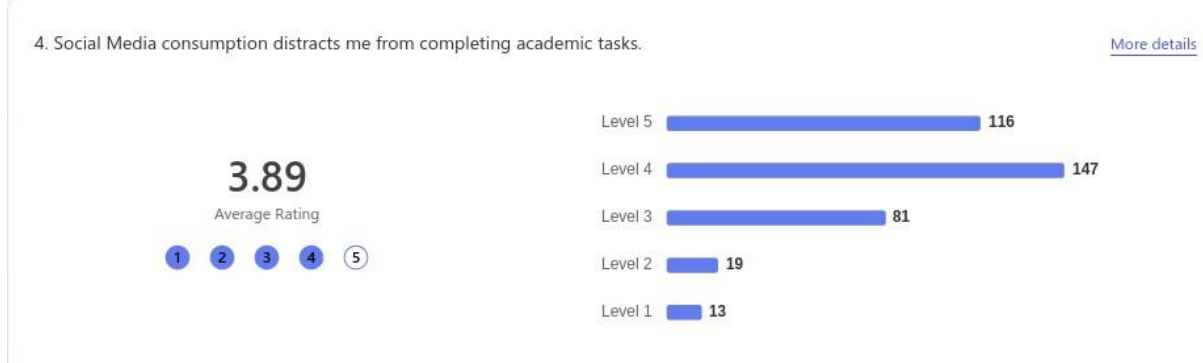


Figure 4: Student ratings of social media distraction from academic tasks (n=380)

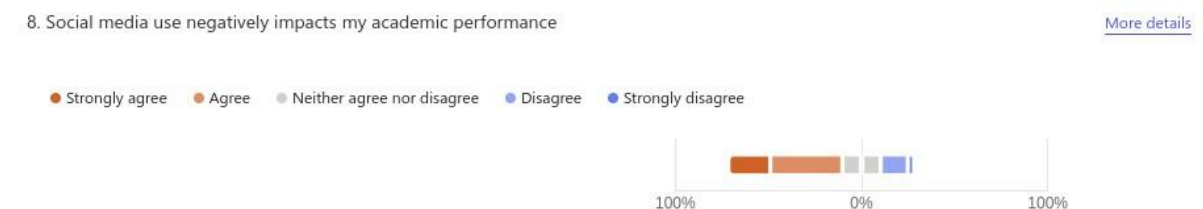


Figure 5: Student agreement on whether social media negatively impacts academic performance (n=380)

The academic activity most often identified as affected was independent studying, selected by 53% of respondents, followed by assignments at 28% and exam preparation at 17%. These findings are broadly consistent with Kirschner and Karpinski's (2010) research, which found that Facebook users spent significantly fewer hours studying per week than non-users and reported lower grades. However, an interesting distinction emerges: whilst Kirschner and Karpinski found that over 73% of students in their study believed social media had no impact on their academic performance, the present survey suggests that today's students are considerably more self-aware. The high agreement rates across questions 4, 5 and 8 indicate that the majority of respondents do recognise and acknowledge the academic harm caused by their social media habits, even if, as the self-regulation data suggests, this awareness does not always translate into sustained behaviour change.

Theme 3 - Wellbeing Effects

The wellbeing findings seemed to be consistently negative. When asked about social media's effect on stress levels, 51% of respondents said that it increases their stress, compared to just 19% who felt it decreases stress. One of the most noticeable findings came from Question 11: 47% of respondents reported feeling less motivated after using social media, compared to only 7% who felt more motivated (*see Figure 6*), meaning students are almost seven times more likely to feel demotivated than energised after social media use. When asked to rank the effects of social media on their wellbeing, respondents placed motivation levels as the most significantly affected dimension, followed by mood or emotional state, stress and anxiety, sleep quality, and sense of social connection.



Figure 6: Perceived effect of social media use on student motivation levels ($n=380$)

Sleep emerged as another significant area of concern, with 63.6% of respondents agreeing or strongly agreeing that social media use affects their sleep quality (*see Figure 7*). This is consistent with Twenge and Campbell's (2018) observation that smartphone use, especially in bedroom environments, is associated with reduced sleep duration and quality amongst adolescents and young adults, a pattern that appears clearly reflected in this student sample.

12. Social media use affects my sleep quality

[More details](#)



Figure 7: Student agreement on whether social media affects sleep quality (n=380)

The data also provided support for the self-esteem and social comparison dynamics identified by Hawi and Samaha (2016) and Hou et al. (2019), albeit indirectly. The combination of increased stress, reduced motivation and disrupted sleep reported by respondents is consistent with the erosion of self-perception described, where the cumulative effects of social comparison and compulsive use wear down students' sense of confidence and wellbeing over time.

Theme 4 - Self-Regulation and the Desire for Change

Perhaps the most compelling theme to emerge from the data is students' relationship with self-regulation. A substantial 75% of respondents reported having attempted to reduce their social media usage at some point, a figure that speaks to a widespread awareness of the problem and a genuine desire to improve. However, of those who attempted to reduce their use, only 21% reported being successful long term, whilst 65% were only successful in the short term and 14% were entirely unsuccessful (*see Figure 8*). This pattern of high motivation, limited sustained success, closely mirrors the findings of Hou et al. (2019), whose intervention study demonstrated that without structured support, students struggle to maintain reductions in social media use even when they are motivated to do so.

16. If 'yes', was your attempt successful

[More details](#)

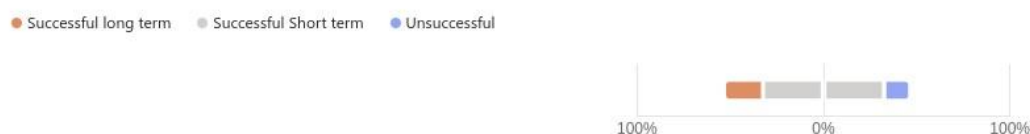


Figure 8: Self-reported success rates of attempts to reduce social media usage (n=380)

The data on management tools reinforces this picture. Despite 75% of students having attempted to reduce their usage, only 31% reported using tools such as screen time limiters or app blockers to support that effort. Of those who did use tools, the most commonly cited were Apple's built-in Screen Time feature and third-party app blockers such as the Forest app, suggesting that awareness of available tools is limited and that uptake remains low relative to need.

Despite these challenges, the data ends on a cautiously optimistic note. A clear majority, 79% of respondents, reported planning to use social media more mindfully in the future (*see*

Figure 9). This finding, combined with high rates of attempted reduction and strong agreement on questions 7 and 13, where 73.4% felt more focused when limiting use and 59.7% felt their mood improved when taking breaks, suggests that students are not passive in the face of these challenges. There is a genuine and widespread desire for a healthier relationship with technology, even where the practical means to achieve it remain underdeveloped.

19. Do you plan to use social media more mindfully in future?



Figure 9: Student intentions to use social media more mindfully in future (n=380)

Evaluation

This study aimed to explore how students perceive the effects of social media consumption on their productivity and wellbeing. Reflecting on the research process as a whole, I believe the investigation largely achieved its aims, producing a substantial and coherent dataset that yielded clear, consistent findings across all four themes. However, a number of limitations and areas for improvement are worth acknowledging.

The primary research method, an online survey distributed via student networks, proved effective in generating a large volume of responses. With 380 participants, the dataset is considerably larger than many published studies in this field, lending a degree of credibility to the findings. The mix of question formats, combining Likert scales, multiple choice and ranking questions, allowed for both measurable quantitative data and more nuanced attitudinal responses, which enriched the analysis. The decision to focus on student perceptions rather than attempting to measure behaviour directly was appropriate given the scope of an independent study, and produced findings that were both accessible and meaningful.

However, several limitations must be acknowledged. The most significant limitation being the self-report nature of the survey. As noted in the methodology, responses reflect how students perceive their own social media use and its effects, rather than objectively recorded behaviour. Research by Kirschner and Karpinski (2010) demonstrated that students often underestimate or misreport the impact of social media on their studies, suggesting that selfreport data in this area should be interpreted with caution. Whilst the present findings

suggest that today's students are more self-aware than those in earlier studies, the possibility of response bias cannot be entirely ruled out.

The sampling method also presents limitations. The survey was distributed via online student networks, reaching predominantly UK university students, and participation was entirely selfselecting. This means the sample may overrepresent students who are already engaged with and reflective about their social media use, precisely those who would be most likely to notice and acknowledge its effects. Students who are entirely disengaged from this topic, or who use social media without concern, may be underrepresented in the data, which could skew findings towards more negative perceptions than would be found in a fully random sample.

The decision not to collect demographic information such as age, gender or year of study was a further limitation. Several studies in the literature, including Simsek et al. (2019) and Hawi and Samaha (2016), identified noticeable differences in social media use and its effects across gender. Without this data, it was not possible to explore whether similar patterns existed within the present sample, representing a missed opportunity for a more detailed analysis.

In terms of the research more broadly, the study would have benefited from a small number of follow-up interviews with student volunteers. Whilst the survey captured perceptions effectively at a quantitative level, interviews would have allowed for deeper exploration of individual experiences, particularly around self-regulation attempts and the reasons why long-term reduction proved difficult for the majority of respondents. This is an area that future research in this topic could usefully address.

Despite these limitations, the study succeeded in its primary aim. The findings were consistent, clearly structured and well-supported by the existing literature, and the sample size gives meaningful weight to the conclusions drawn.

Conclusions

This study set out to investigate the question: how do students perceive the effects of social media consumption on their productivity and wellbeing? Drawing on a review of existing academic literature and primary survey data gathered from 380 UK university students, the research has produced a clear and consistent set of findings that both support and extend the existing body of knowledge in this area.

The evidence suggests that social media use amongst students is extensive, largely habitual, and widely perceived as detrimental to both academic performance and personal wellbeing. Usage is driven overwhelmingly by entertainment and habit rather than intention, yet consistently disrupts the academic activities students are attempting to engage in. Across the wellbeing dimensions explored, students reported increased stress, disrupted sleep, and a near seven-to-one ratio of feeling demotivated to energised following social media use, with motivation ranked as the most significantly affected dimension of wellbeing overall.

Perhaps the most significant finding of this study concerns the gap between awareness and action. Three quarters of respondents have actively attempted to reduce their social media use, demonstrating a level of self-awareness that perhaps exceeds what earlier research predicted. Yet only one in five of those attempts succeeded long term. This tension between intention and sustained change echoes the conclusions of Hou et al. (2019), whose intervention research demonstrated that structured, supported approaches to reducing social media addiction produce significantly better outcomes than individual willpower alone. The fact that 79% of respondents plan to use social media more mindfully in future, combined with the low uptake of available management tools, suggests that students are ready and willing to change, but may lack the knowledge, support or strategies to do so effectively.

This points towards a clear practical implication: universities may have an important role to play in supporting students to develop healthier, more intentional relationships with technology. Whether through digital literacy programmes, awareness campaigns, or the signposting of evidence-based self-regulation strategies, there is a meaningful opportunity for institutions to respond to what is clearly a widespread and largely unmet need.

Social media is not going away, and nor should it- its benefits for communication, learning and connection are genuine and should not be dismissed. But for the current generation of students, navigating an environment deliberately engineered to capture their attention, the development of intentional, self-regulated digital habits may be one of the most important skills for students in modern education. As digital platforms continue to shape student life, learning how to manage attention may become just as important as managing time.

References

- Andreassen, C.S., Billieux, J., Griffiths, M.D., Kuss, D.J., Demetrovics, Z., Mazzoni, E. and Pallesen, S. (2016) *Bergen Social Media Addiction Scale (BSMAS)* [Database record]. APA PsycTests. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1037/t74607-000>
- Griffiths, M.D. (2013) 'Social networking addiction: Emerging themes and issues', *Journal of Addiction Research and Therapy*, 4(5). Available at: <https://doi.org/10.4172/21556105.1000e118>
- Hari, J. (2022) *Stolen Focus: Why You Can't Pay Attention*. New York: Crown.
- Hawi, N.S. and Samaha, M. (2016) 'The relations among social media addiction, self-esteem, and life satisfaction in university students', *Social Science Computer Review*, 35(4), pp.576–586. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1177/0894439316660340>
- Hou, Y., Xiong, D., Jiang, T., Song, L. and Wang, Q. (2019) 'Social media addiction: Its impact, mediation, and intervention', *Cyberpsychology: Journal of Psychosocial Research on Cyberspace*, 13(1), article 4. Available at: <http://dx.doi.org/10.5817/CP2019-1-4>

Kirschner, P.A. and Karpinski, A.C. (2010) 'Facebook and academic performance', *Computers in Human Behavior*, 26(6), pp.1237–1245. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2010.03.024>

Newport, C. (2019) *Digital Minimalism: Choosing a Focused Life in a Noisy World*. New York: Portfolio/Penguin.

Simsek, A., Elciyar, K. and Kizilhan, T. (2019) 'A comparative study on social media addiction of high school and university students', *Contemporary Educational Technology*, 10(2), pp.106–119. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.30935/cet.554452>

Twenge, J.M. and Campbell, W.K. (2018) 'Associations between screen time and lower psychological well-being among children and adolescents: Evidence from a population-based study', *Preventive Medicine Reports*, 12, pp.271–283. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pmedr.2018.10.003>

Williams, J. (2018) *Stand Out of Our Light: Freedom and Resistance in the Attention Economy*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.